

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 792

By Keisling

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of General Tom P.
"Tommy" Thompson, Jr., of Hartsville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of General Tom P. "Tommy" Thompson, Jr.; and

WHEREAS, Tommy Thompson was a consummate professional with more than five decades of legal and civic service who was widely respected for his integrity, deep sense of justice, and unwavering commitment to the people he served; and

WHEREAS, born and raised in Hartsville, Mr. Thompson graduated from Castle Heights Military Academy in 1960 and earned his undergraduate degree from Centre College in 1964; he began his career as a teacher at Castle Heights and Trousdale County High School before pursuing a law degree at Vanderbilt University, graduating in 1969; and

WHEREAS, following law school, he served honorably in the United States Army as the Chief Legal Officer of the Army Training Center at Fort Bragg until 1971, setting the course for a lifetime devoted to public service; and

WHEREAS, after serving as Assistant District Attorney General in Nashville, Tommy Thompson returned to Hartsville in 1973 to practice law alongside his father; in 1977, the Governor appointed him District Attorney General for the 15th Judicial District, which includes Wilson, Smith, Macon, Jackson, and Trousdale counties, and he was subsequently elected to that position for six consecutive terms beginning in 1978; and

WHEREAS, during his tenure as District Attorney General, Mr. Thompson shaped the criminal justice system in his district and mentored countless attorneys, who credit him with defining their careers and values; he was a tireless advocate for victims and helped establish

the 15th Judicial District Child Advocacy Center, a nonprofit organization that supports victims of abuse; and

WHEREAS, in recognition of his career and public service, Cumberland University established the General Tom P. Thompson, Jr. Professorship in Criminal Justice, ensuring that future generations will benefit from the principles he championed; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Thompson was one of the longest-serving prosecutors in Tennessee history; he was widely respected for his fairness, humility, and steady leadership, earning a reputation as a prosecutor who treated everyone with dignity—whether victims seeking justice, community members looking for guidance, or defendants in need of understanding, he had a rare ability to connect with people from all walks of life; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his work in law enforcement, Tommy Thompson devoted fifty years of service to the Board of Tri-County Electric Membership Corporation, twenty-nine of which he served as Chairman; under his leadership, the Cooperative expanded reliable electricity and brought high-speed internet to rural communities across Tennessee and Kentucky, strengthening the quality of life for families and businesses throughout the region; and

WHEREAS, he also served on the Board of Directors of Citizens Bank in Hartsville, where he played a key role in helping the small-town institution grow and compete in today's complex and competitive financial world without sacrificing the hometown character and personal service that made the bank a cornerstone of the community; and

WHEREAS, in his spare time, Tommy Thompson found solace and joy on his farm in Hartsville, where he cherished the simple, grounding routines of raising cattle and tending the land. His farm was a sanctuary and a place to spend quality time with his children and grandchildren, passing down wisdom and traditions; and

WHEREAS, he loved attending bull sales with his brothers, swapping stories in small-town cafés and taverns, and discovering the character of the people and places that make rural Tennessee and Kentucky unique; he had a lifelong appreciation for history, a fondness for old westerns, and loved climbing into his John Deere tractor with his beloved Labrador Retriever, Deke; and

WHEREAS, above all, Tommy Thompson was a devoted son, husband, father, brother, grandfather, and uncle; he was preceded in death by his parents, Tom Price Thompson and Margaret King Thompson, and is survived by his loving wife of fifty-six years, Baxie; his three children, Price, Lissa (Bill) Vestevich, and Keith (Meredith) Thompson; his seven grandchildren, Anna Baxter, Ashlyn, Robert, Charlotte, Nicholas, Will, and Thomas; his brothers, John (Jan) Thompson, Eric Thompson, and Maben (Julie) Thompson; and many cousins, nieces, nephews, and close friends; and

WHEREAS, General Tommy Thompson will be remembered for his dignified leadership, his lifelong service to the State of Tennessee, his devotion to family, and his enduring connection to his community; his legacy lives on in the thousands of lives he touched, the communities he steadfastly served, and the family that will forever cherish his memory; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of General Tom P. "Tommy" Thompson, Jr., reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Thompson.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.